

Into Cyberspace And Back

IBM will work with Circuit City to explore retail business models in 3D virtual worlds. The companies hope to discover how such environments can be utilised to improve customer experiences with brands, and have built a digital store on an IBM's island in *Second Life*.



The Last Windows?

Research firm Gartner has predicted that Vista will be the last major Windows release. "The era of monolithic deployments of software releases is nearing an end," Gartner has said. The prediction went on, "Microsoft will participate in the trend toward more flexible updates."



Enter

Tanushree Dutta
Model and Actress

The now-well-known actress got her first glimpse of fame with the Ponds Femina Miss India Universe 2004 award. She is best known for her performances in *Aashiq Banaya Aapne* and *Chocolate*.



Technology...

Helps one in day-to-day life. People's entire life revolves around technology, and has now become an integral part of our lives.

What gadgets do you use?

I use a laptop, and of course, a mobile—a Nokia N72 to be precise. I also have a handycam and an iPod.

What would be your dream gadget be?

Something that would read people's minds...

What do you mostly do online?

I chat with my friends, e-mail, and I go online if I need to watch movie trailers. I also listen to music online and download MP3s. I don't watch movies online, and would prefer to go to a theatre—or watch them on my DVD player.

An instance where technology has really helped you?

Technology has always helped me. One instance I can recall is when I was in college: my vehicle broke down at night on a lonely road, and it was quite a distance to walk. Thanks to my mobile, I was able to call my friends for help.

LINUX EVERYWHERE

Europe Wants It, Won't Do It

Like many Asian countries, European governments want to shift to Linux—in some cases entirely—in a bid to save money and break free of the MS\$ hegemony. But not just for these reasons.

There are several interesting perspectives on why it is that Europe wants to take the lead in moving to the OSS business model, much more so than the United States does, for example.

Xavier Cazin, a Chief Editor at O'Reilly Editions France, has an interesting take: as computers become a daily necessity, the French philosophical perspective has led people to revolt. "The more the role of something is essential, the less it should cost. People hate paying for something that is unavoidable. That's why French people didn't feel guilty in pirating Microsoft software for years."

But unfortunately, most of the current talk is rhetoric in nature, and it's a case of I-can't-get-myself-to-do-it. Or something like "the spirit is willing but the flesh is weak," in dramatic terms.

One official put it thus: "If the technicians say 'no', it's not going to happen." And why, indeed, are the technicians saying "no"? For all the basic reasons: compatibility issues, conflicts with MS Exchange Servers, and the problem of educating governmental IT departments about Linux, OpenOffice and more.

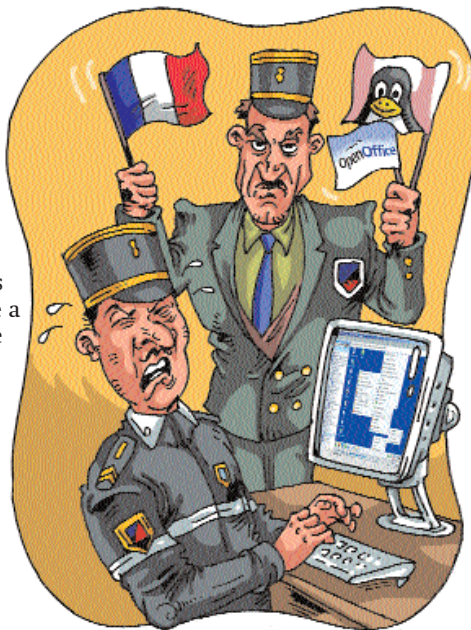


Illustration Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

The suspects and the figures: elected officials have, for some time now, been making a fuss about migrating to open source on major scales. Migrations of governmental computers in France, Germany, Norway, and Spain have been planned at some point or the other, but few departments have actually

done the migrating. According to market research firm IDC, more than 95 per cent of all PCs used by government workers in Europe still run on Windows.

The most ambitious open source initiative in Europe thus far was a project by the local government in Spain's Extremadura region, which has managed to migrate some 75,000 PCs to Linux. Tellingly, some of the computers in the project's administrative office still run Windows, an employee told Wired News. Under condition of anonymity, of course.

The drive continues. France, in particular, is trying to hasten the crossover, as we indicated above. Over the next few months, lawmakers in France's National Assembly will start using Linux, OpenOffice, and Firefox on PCs. The official reason stated goes thus: the French government's push away from Microsoft platforms is driven in large part concerns about security and industrial espionage in the economic war between Europe and the US.

In the case of the French Gendarmes—the police department—the PCs used by the 1,00,000-member police force run almost entirely on Windows. The unit plans to make 5,000 of its PCs run under Linux this